

03 COSTA MUERTA

ADVENTURE 3: COSTA MUERTA — PART 2: THE SALE

Status: TO RUN — one focused session (~3–3.5 hrs). Picks up in Tijuana and runs the credibility gate, the sale, and the getaway. The road south is in `part-1-the-long-road.md`.

How this doc is laid out: Part A — Read-Ahead is prep reading (mood, cast, how the sale works). Part B — Run Sheets is one scannable page per encounter for use at the table. Part C — Reference holds the buyer board and stat blocks. Don't read Part A aloud; run from Part B.

PART A — READ-AHEAD & INSPIRATION

Read once before the session. Not for the table.

WHERE WE LEFT OFF

The team drove two sealed Arasaka droneware units south to sell at **Costa Muerta**, the monthly black-market biotech auction on the rig-city of **Nueva Costa**, timed to Día de los Muertos. As played in Session 1: rolling in the **cargo van**, fought off **Don Bicho** (he *survived* — a live grudge on the road home), held the **Snake's Nest** with only **minor injuries**, banked strong **Aldecaldos** goodwill (but **declined the snake tattoo**), and crossed into **Tijuana**. They carry **Mateo's letter** to Tía Esmé.

Confirm before play: camp-defense tier (was Reyna's cousin among the wounded?), Fredrik's installed chrome, Kojo's brokerage %, current HP/Humanity.

THE ONE THING THAT MAKES THIS SESSION MAKE SENSE

You don't negotiate with buyers, then also auction. You earn the *right to sell*, then the auction is real.

- **Before the sale:** the house (the Costa Muerta syndicates) vets the sellers — are they legit, are they cops, will they fold? That vetting is Doña Esperanza's **worm-mezcal vision-quest** and the **exhibition bout**. Pass, and you're cleared to put the lot on the floor.
- **The auction is a genuine auction** — open bids. The players' agency is in *shaping the room*: set the reserve, hype the lot, spot the skill, and make **one call at the hammer** — the top cash number, or a rival's lower bid **plus a relationship**. That live choice is the whole “whose card do you carry” theme; it no longer happens on paper in advance.
- **The rig is cartel-secured, so the fight isn't there.** The players can't out-gun a syndicate fortress and shouldn't try. The danger is the one place they're isolated and decisive: **the helipad, on the way out**.

THE CAST (LEAN — FIVE PEOPLE CARRY THE SESSION)

- **Ofelia “Ofi” Castañeda** — the handler. Early 40s, runs a flower shop that's really grief-logistics for a cartel city (she buries a lot of people's sons; launders through funeral wreaths). Dry, unsentimental, allergic to amateurs. *Not* muscle, *not* a face — she's logistics and consequences. Her whole arc is watching these northerners agree to things she can't get them out of.
- **Doña Esperanza Vargas** — Los Curanderos matriarch, ripperdoc-syndicate boss, religious in a dark way, rules from a deconsecrated cathedral. **She runs the vetting** (the worm-mezcal ritual is pure her) **and she's also a bidder**. The house that judges you also wants your lot. Evaluates people like cattle; means what she says.

- **Reyna Solano “La Viuda”** — cyber-lucha star. Sandevistan + monomolecular fan. Broke, wants out of the circuit, Aldecaldos-connected. Fredrik’s opponent in the “friendly” bout → future ally. She fights *honorable*; the danger in the ring is the *setup*, not her.
- **Mr. Vega** — Militech cutout. Smooth, ex-SF, knows their NC file cold. One approach, one offer: the extradition shield. Selling to him makes them Militech assets — they call, you answer.
- **Tía Esmé Aldecaldo** — Aldecaldos rep, already warm (Mateo’s letter + the camp defense). Low cash, priceless family bond. She just *greet*s them at the rig — no cold pitch needed.
- **Iku Tanaka** (*the trap*) — Arasaka counterintel. Registered as a buyer but his story doesn’t check out. **Glimpsed in the vision-quest** as a cold, wrong presence; **absent from the auction** = the tell. Coordinates the Section-9 raid from a submersible. Never meant to buy — only to find the lot and seize it.

VISION-QUEST — INSPIRATION BANK

It’s a **neural interrogation in a poncho** — a BD-worm sim Doña walks with them as psychopomp, not literal magic. Día-de-Muertos dreamscape: a marigold road, a *mercado de los muertos*, ancestors as data-ghosts. It strips social armor so she can read intent. Give players real choices in the haze. Vignettes to pick from: - **The marigold road** — walk it without looking back; who looks back, and at what? - **The market of the dead** — a vendor offers to buy one of their memories. What’s it worth? What do they refuse to sell? - **Your own altar** — each PC sees an altar with their photo on it. Who’s standing at it mourning? (Fredrik’s is the gut-punch — tie to his therapy arc.) - **The cold guest** — one soul in the market casts no shadow and mourns no one. That’s Tanaka’s echo. A curious player can clock it.

PACING

Full session. Natural intermission after the bout (Tijuana done, before the chopper). **If running long**: compress the chip-up to two lines, and drop the auction’s hype sub-game — go straight to bids and the hammer. Don’t cut the vision-quest or the extraction; they’re the tentpoles.

DV KEY

11 Easy · 13 Standard · 15 Difficult · 17 Hard · 19 Very Hard.

PART B — RUN SHEETS

1 • WAKE AT OFELIA'S

Set the board • RP • ~10 min

Setup: Morning above the flower shop, Zona Norte. Marigolds everywhere for the festival. The units are in Ofelia's floor-safe.

"Kojo says treat you like family. So — family rules. The apartment's yours till the sale. The shop's mine. Steal a carnation and I shoot you in the femoral. Now sit, because you don't understand how this works yet."

What's going on: - Ofi lays out the reframe (players learn it here): **you can't just sell.** The Costa Muerta syndicates vet every seller of a hot lot. No blessing, no floor. - Two gates before they're cleared: **(1)** sit with **Doña Esperanza** today — "she'll read you"; **(2)** whatever she asks of you after. - The sale itself is a **real auction on the rig, tomorrow night.** House takes **12%** of cash. Non-cash favors aren't taxed.

Player beats: - Questions about the buyers → give them **The Board** (Part C) as intel Ofi rattles off. - Anyone pushing to skip the vetting and deal privately: Ofi shuts it down flat — *"Walk a sale around the house and they feed you to the rig."*

Exits: Ofi drives them to the cathedral for the sit-down with Doña. → **Sheet 2.**

2 · THE VETTING

Credibility gate + seed the trap · RP / neural set-piece · ~30 min

Setup: Doña's deconsecrated cathedral. Candles, a ripperdoc bay behind the altar, a bottle of black mezcal with a live cyber-worm coiled at the bottom. She pours four.

"Words lie. Blood lies. The worm does not. Drink with me, and let me see who came into my house."

What's going on: - The **worm is a BD-jack**. Swallow it and the room dissolves into a shared Día-de-Muertos dreamscape (see inspiration bank). Doña walks it with them. **It's her lie-detector**. Refuse = fail the vetting (no sale). - She's checking three things: *are they real sellers, are they a plant, will they break*.

Player beats (give agency in the haze): - **Confession** — an ancestor-figure (or Doña) asks each PC what they *truly* want from this sale. **Honesty is safe and builds her trust**. Lying to her sim: DECEPTION vs her Insight (**DV 17**) — fail and she reads it, and turns cold (worse auction posture, no floor-waiver later). - **The cold guest** — a soul in the market casts no shadow, mourns no one. Clock it (HUMAN PERCEPTION or INTERFACE **DV 15**) → they've spotted **Tanaka's echo**. He's registered to bid but he is *wrong*. (This is the early trap seed — reward it.) - **The bargain** — euphoric, loose, Fredrik is offered a "friendly game — show us your prowess." He agrees. A lucid PC can grab the reins (WILL/COOL **DV 15**) to set terms or dodge — **but dodging reads as fear and costs credibility** (Doña's read drops a tier). Best play: agree, look strong.

Exits: They surface hours later, cleared to sell. Fredrik is booked on tomorrow's Día lucha card. Doña's read of them (warm / guarded / cold) is a dial you carry into the auction. → **Sheet 3**.

3 · “OH MY GOD”

Stakes reveal + prep · RP · ~10 min

Setup: Back at the shop. Ofi makes a call, goes white, hangs up.

“A friendly exhibition. Ay, Dios. You agreed to fight La Viuda — top of the card. And the promoters are taking bets on the northerner getting cut. ‘Friendly.’ They ‘forgot’ to lock her blade.”

What’s going on: - The bout is billed non-lethal, but Doña quietly let Reyna’s **monomolecular fan stay live** — she wants to see Fredrik under *real* threat. The betting circuit smells blood on the outsider. - Ofi scrambles to even the odds. This is fast — Fredrik’s already the fighter, so it’s a top-up, not a shopping trip.

Player beats — Ofi can source, quickly (cash or favor): - Arena-legal chrome for Fredrik he doesn’t already run: **Big Knux** (100eb), a one-shot **Sandevistan** trigger (1,000eb), **Subdermal Armor** (1,000eb). - **Intel on Reyna** (STREETWISE DV 13): Sandevistan opener, fan is her only lethal option, she fights *clean by choice* — she won’t kill him if he gives her a way not to. - Mats/Digitz plan their corner game (spot the blade, jam it, work the crowd — see Sheet 4).

Exits: That night → La Plaza Hueso. → **Sheet 4**.

4 · THE EXHIBITION

Fredrik's spotlight · light combat · ~30 min

Setup: La Plaza Hueso, a converted bullring. 4,000 in face paint, brass band, sold out. **Doña watches from a private box** — she is scoring the *crowd*, not the falls. Two falls out of three.

What's going on: - **Fredrik vs Reyna, singles.** Firearms/monoblades banned by rule — but her fan is live (Sheet 3). First blood reveals it. - Reyna is a **glass cannon** who **will not kill him** — she pulls lethal strikes and telegraphs an honorable out. If Fredrik fights with honor (no dirty corner-work), she salutes him. If Mats/Digitz cheat blatantly, the *crowd* turns — and that's what Doña scores. - **Reyna clocks them as Aldecaldos** on entrance (her cousin, from the camp) — “¡Aldecaldos!” — a fist raised across the ring. Faction goodwill, made public.

Player beats: - **Fredrik (in ring):** run 3 narrative rounds, ~2 rolls each (his best combat skill vs Reyna's Evasion/attacks). Fall milestones, not HP-to-zero — he can't die here, he can get *cut*. - **Corner (Mats/Digitz):** spot the live fan (PERCEPTION **DV 13**) → jam it (TECH/NET **DV 15**, removes the lethal threat) · rile the front row to break her focus (PERSUASION **DV 13**, +1 to Fredrik) · **any blatant assist loses the crowd.**

Stat block:

FIGHTER	HP	SP	ATTACK	NOTE
Reyna “La Viuda”	35	9	Cyberarm 3d6 · Sandevisitan 1×/ fight · fan (live) 4d6	Fast, honorable, won't finish him

Outcome (what Doña saw): - **Won/lost with honor, crowd loud** → Doña impressed; the **lot gains standing** (opening bids +~10%). Reyna seeks them out after — wants a word, later. - **Won dirty, crowd flat** → Doña: “*estilo, pero no honor.*” Standing flat. Reyna cool. - **Vega approaches** in the tunnel after, either way. → hands a card, one line: “*Interested parties from the north. We'll speak on the floor.*” (His whole pre-auction footprint — that's it.)

Exits: Intermission point. Next day, chopper to the rig. → **Sheet 5.**

5 · TRANSIT

Scene-break · ~5 min, no rolls

Setup: Seawall helipad at sundown. Ofelia is door agent; she keeps the sealed case and the **Ricochet loads onto the chopper** (“stays with the bird — house won’t let it on the floor”). Buyers’ reps board the same flight.

“Two units, sealed by me. The bird stays hot on the pad out there — my pilot doesn’t cut engines till everyone’s back or everyone’s dead. Remember which one you’d rather be.”

What’s going on (planting the getaway): - 35 min west over the Pacific; Nueva Costa rises as a constellation of lashed-together oil platforms. - **House rules, stated on arrival:** long guns checked at the armory (one concealed sidearm each; Fredrik’s internal Pop-up VHP isn’t “a gun”). The floor is patrolled by the **Pacers** (syndicate peacekeepers) — the players are *not* the security here and can’t out-fight the house. - Establish the geography they’ll flee through later: **Salón → single caged gangway → helipad deck, chopper spooling.**

Exits: The Salón, Lot 4 coming up. → **Sheet 6.**

6 · THE AUCTION

The sale, with real agency · RP set-piece · ~40 min

Setup: The *Salón de la Casa Muerta* — a converted hangar, skulls and marigolds, a masked auctioneer mic'd to the room. Droneware is **Lot 4**, sold as a sealed pair (Ofi's rule). **Tanaka's chair is empty.**

Before bidding — players set terms (their levers): - **Reserve** — a cash floor below which they walk (failed lot returns, minus 5,000eb fee). - **Pair or split** — Ofi advises pair; splitting invites the wrong buyers.

During — each PC gets ONE room action: - **Mats** — **hype the provenance** (PERSUASION DV 15): sealed Arasaka R&D, Voss's own seal → pushes the whole field up a tier. - **Fredrik** — **the arena rep** (intimidation/presence, DV 13): stares down a lowballing shill; discourages timid money. - **Digitz** — **scan the room** (INTERFACE DV 15): flags a **shill bidder** driving price with no funds — *and* flags that **Tanaka's absence means a buyer with the location and no intent to pay.** (If they clocked his echo on Sheet 2, this lands as confirmation: *a raid is coming.*)

The tell: a sharp table should now be nervous — Tanaka knows where they are and isn't bidding. Let them decide to **expedite / prep the getaway.** That unease *is* the bridge to Sheet 7.

The hammer — the choice (see The Board, Part C): - Top cash number, **or** a rival's lower bid + **their relationship** (Militech shield / Aldecaldos bond / Curanderos clinic). - **80% floor:** the accepted bid must be ≥80% of the top cash bid. **Tía Esmé's number is below it** — to take the Aldecaldos bond, either push her cash up (PERSUASION DV 17; the room just proved corps want this) or get a **floor-waiver from Doña** (DV 15 if her read of them is warm — the vetting pays off here).

Exits: Hammer falls. Delivery completes **on landing back in TJ** — so the sealed case and the winning buyer's rep fly out *with the players*. They head for the helipad. → **Sheet 7.**

7 • THE EXTRACTION

The tactical set-piece • hard combat • ~50 min

Setup: The caged gangway to the helipad deck. Wind, sea-spray, night. Chopper spooling — **needs the case aboard + 3 rounds to lift**. As they step onto the deck, the rig's floods die: **Section-9 is boarding**. Tanaka's real play — seize the case before it leaves the rig.

```
[ SALÓN exit ]
|
caged gangway <-- chokepoint (1-wide)
|
~~~~~ HELIPAD DECK ~~~~~
[fuel drum][drum]      ((crane arm))
      . CHOPPER (spooling, Ofi + pilot) .
[container]            [container]
--- railing --- ocean, 30m drop --- railing ---
  ▲ Section-9 fast-rope in + climb the rig legs
```

(Printable tactical map: [map-helipad.svg](#).)

Objectives: get the case + the winning buyer's rep + all PCs aboard and lift off before Section-9 secures the deck. Losing the case = the sale unwinds (payment clawed back, ally's trust gone).

What matters tactically (reward smart play): - **The Ricochet is on the chopper** — reach it and Digitz can slave it (INTERFACE DV 13) → deck-sweeper, turns the fight. - **Kill the Team Lead's micro-drone** (called shot / NET) → Section-9 loses its coordination + spotting (drop their effective attacks). - **Fuel drums** = 6d6 AoE if shot. **Crane arm** = Digitz can swing it (DV 15) to sweep the gangway. **Gangway** = a 1-wide chokepoint the players can hold. - **The rig disarmed them** — sidearms + Fredrik's VHP + melee only until they reach the Ricochet. Real constraint; makes the chopper the prize. - **Their ally fights** (depends on who they sold to): - **Vega** → his staffer reveals a Sandevistan + 4d6 smart-pistol — *terrifying*. - **Tía Esmé** → two Aldecaldos cousins, steady guns. - **Doña** → her bodyguard; Doña herself will take a hit to save “her property.” - **Clean/anonymous bidder** → **no ally**. You chose cash over friends — you fight alone. (Let this land.)

Clock: Round 1 lights out + first contact • Rounds 2–3 breach the deck, drone spots, grenades on the gangway • Round 3+ chopper is flight-ready — every round on the deck after is a grenade/ Sandevistan rush for the case • **Section-9 breaks if they lose 4, or immediately if the Lead falls.**

Stat block:

TYPE	SP	HP	WEAPON	NOTES
Section-9 Operator ×5	15	45	SMG 4d6 · frag · Sandevisitan	Coordinated; never freelances
Section-9 Team Lead	17	55	Tech-rifle 5d6 · micro-drone (spotter)	Kill drone → team loses coordination

If the players tipped Tanaka off (caught him and showed it), add 2 operators. Tanaka stays on the sub — unreachable — and pulls out the moment the grab fails.

Exits: Lift-off. Section-9 tags the chopper with a tracker dart (AWARENESS **DV 15** to find & dump it, or accept Tanaka knows where they land). → **Sheet 8**.



8 · AFTERMATH

Payoff + Adv 4 threads · RP · ~10 min

The chopper lifts. Below, the Pacers are dragging Section-9 bodies off the gangways; the Lead is dead, the survivors are the syndicates' prisoners now. Tanaka's sub is already gone.

Payout (net after 12% house cut; see Part C for the board): - Sold to **Vega** → ~176,000eb + **Militech extradition shield** (you're an asset now — they call, you answer) - Sold to **Doña** → ~132,000eb + **Curanderos clinic-for-life** - Sold to **Tía Esmé** (negotiated up) → ~132,000eb + **Aldecaldos family bond** - Sold to **clean bidder** → ~185,000eb, **no relationship** (and you fought the deck alone)

Faction fallout: - **Whoever won** → strong ally if a relationship deal; cold-neutral if pure cash. - **Tía Esmé / Aldecaldos** → warm regardless (the letter, the camp, Reyna's salute). Bond unlocked if sold to her. - **Tanaka / Arasaka** → hostile but *bloodied*. Section-9 took a real loss; they back off a while. They have the team on file now. - **Don Bicho** → still out there, twice-humiliated, owns the road north. Unresolved. - **Reyna** → free agent, honors the team, sends a painted cyber-mask: "*For when you next come south.*" - **Kojo** → paid, delighted, sends a *handwritten* thank-you (he's never handwritten anything). - **Lazard** → Kojo's word two days on: audit suspended, "reassigned" to an off-grid Arasaka site. Deniably retired. Arc closes; the name is a case file now.

Closing beat — the Day of the Dead. Back in TJ by evening, the parade fills the streets. Fredrik stops at a stranger's altar and looks a long time at photographs of the dead — he hasn't built one for anyone in years. He should think about that. Mats buys flowers. Digitz calls his mentor.

PART C — REFERENCE

THE BOARD (BUYER INTEL — USABLE AS A PLAYER HANDOUT)

BUYER	FACTION	CASH (FINAL, ON FLOOR)	RELATIONSHIP (THE REAL PRIZE)	READ
Mr. Vega	Militech cutout	~200,000eb	Non-extradition shield in Militech territory	Most cash. You become a Militech asset — they call, you answer
Doña Esperanza	Los Curanderos	~150,000eb	Clinic-for-life, all three, forever	Safest. Genuine. She already read your soul
Tía Esmé	Aldecaldos	~70,000eb (<i>below floor</i>)	Family bond — safe passage + backup on every road, for life	Lowest cash, highest lifetime value. Push her up or get Doña's floor-waiver
"Clean" bidder	Anonymous	~210,000eb	None — clean transfer, no ties	Most cash, no friends. Repeats Tanaka's mistake — and you fight the deck alone
Iku Tanaka	"Pacific Rim medical"	(no bid — absent)	(none)	The plant. His empty chair is the warning.

Rules the players operate under: house takes **12%** of *cash* (relationships untaxed) · accepted bid must be **≥80% of top cash bid** (anti-collusion floor) · seller's discretion picks the winner · pair sells sealed.

Final-table extras (after choosing, before the hammer — PERSUASION): DV 13 a favor owed on top · DV 15 non-disclosure (winner won't say who bought) · DV 17 Pacer stand-down so the team can return to Nueva Costa safe.

CONTINUITY INTO ADVENTURE 4

Mole (confirmed alive, surfaces later) · **Don Bicho** (twice-humiliated, owns the road north) · Aldecaldos bond (if taken) · Militech call-in (if sold to Vega) · **Tanaka / Section-9 file** (he escaped; they have the team logged) · Reyna (wants out of the circuit, owes them) · Lazard (deniably retired).